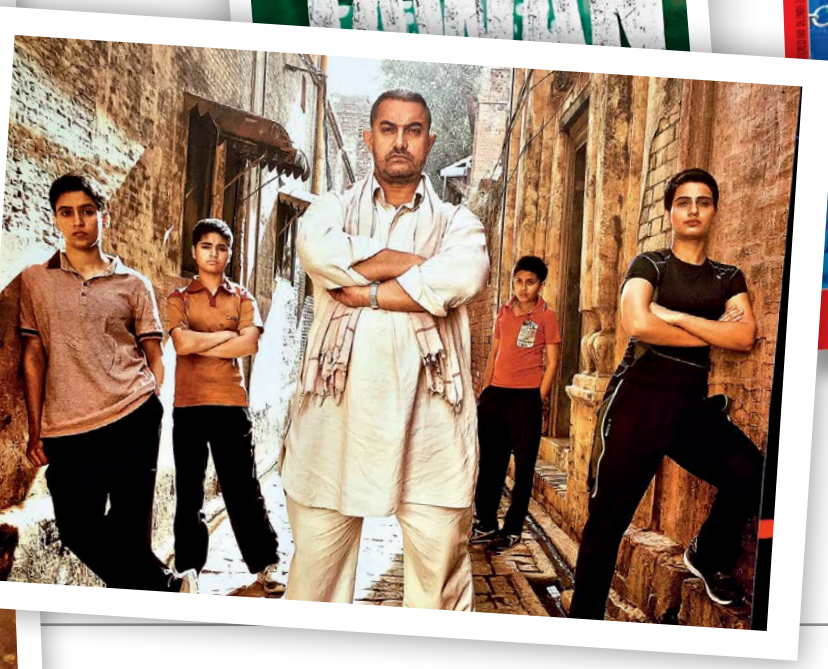






THE TRIO'S HITS Clockwise from left, Aamir's *Dangal*, Salman's *Tiger Zinda Hai;* and SRK's *Jawan* and *Pathaan*





Stills from *Laapataa Ladies* (above) and *All We Imagine as Light*

IT LOST TO *LAAPATAA LADIES* AS OSCAR ENTRY, BUT PAYAL KAPADIA'S *ALL WE IMAGINE AS LIGHT* WOWED CANNES ENOUGH TO WIN A GRAND PRIX

chayat, Bandish Bandits, Scam 1992 (2020); *Maharani* (2021); *Heeramandi* (2024) among them.

OTT emerged an unlikely saviour not only for viewers starved of their entertainment fix at theatres near them during COVID, but also for many a flagging career. Saif Ali Khan dove into *Sacred Games*, Abhishek Bachchan found new footing in *Breathe: Into the Shadows* (2020), Sushmita Sen rediscovered stardom through *Aarya* (2020). Samantha Ruth Prabhu widened her geographic footprint with *The Family Man Season 2* (2021). The OTT hero—Manoj Bajpayee, Pankaj Tripathi, Jaideep Ahlawat, Nawazuddin Siddiqui, Jitendra Kumar—was a creature different from his Bollywood counterpart. What he lacked in chocolatey good looks, he made up with sheer talent and acting sinew. OTT created space for creativity behind the camera too. Its long-form storytelling allowed wider narrative arcs, deeper characterisation and ingenious, less formulaic narratives.